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2026 NORTON SOUND-PORT CLARENCE SALMON SEASON SUMMARY

In 2026, salmon returns to the Norton Sound District supported commercial fisheries targeting chum and coho salmon in the coastal waters of Subdistricts 2–6 with other species harvested incidentally. The total salmon harvest was the highest in the last 4 years but was below the most recent 5-year average. The total value of the fishery was near the recent average, though commercial effort in Norton Sound was the lowest in 20 years. There were no emergency orders restricting subsistence salmon fishing except for Chinook salmon conservation restrictions in Subdistricts 5 and 6 that have been enacted since 2024. Salmon returns varied greatly by species and by subdistrict, but most escapement goals were achieved. This summary contains preliminary numbers that will be updated in subsequent reports.

COMMERCIAL SALMON FISHERY

Salmon returns to Norton Sound varied, with chum salmon achieving all but 1 goal, pink salmon achieving 2 of 3 goals, and Chinook salmon not achieving any established escapement goals (Table 4). Coho salmon goals were achieved at the Kwiniuk River in Subdistrict 3, but North River tower in Subdistrict 6 ceased operations before the coho salmon escapement goal could be met. The sockeye salmon escapement goal in the Port Clarence District was met for the 3rd year in a row. Throughout Norton Sound, pink salmon returns were above average, except in Subdistrict 1 where the pink salmon goal at Nome River was not achieved.

The 2026 Norton Sound commercial harvest of 48,700 salmon was below average, though the fishery value of $320,657 was near the recent 5-year average (Table 1). The commercial effort of 72 permits was the lowest since 2007 and ranged from 5 fishermen in Subdistrict 4 to 28 fishermen in Subdistrict 6 (Table 2). Chum salmon catch of 24,730 fish was double the recent 5-year average and the coho salmon catch of 13,639 fish was near the recent 5-year average (Table 3).

One salmon buyer operated in the region in 2026, Norton Sound Seafood Products (NSSP), with the Unalakleet processing plant being the buyer's main base of operations. NSSP also processed some commercial salmon catch at their plant in Nome. There were no catcher-seller permits registered with the department in 2026. Prices paid per pound in 2026 were $2.20 for sockeye salmon, $1.90 for coho salmon, $0.75 for chum salmon, and $0.35 for pink salmon. The price for all species was the same as in 2025. Chinook salmon were not purchased by NSSP in 2026.

SUBSISTENCE SALMON FISHERY

Subsistence salmon fishermen in the Port Clarence District and Norton Sound Subdistricts 1–3 are required to possess a subsistence permit for each household that fishes in these locations. The permit holder records

the harvest method and the catch in numbers of fish by species for each day fished. Permits are due back to the department by October 6th each year. In southern Norton Sound, census surveys in the communities of Koyuk, Shaktoolik, and Unalakleet estimate subsistence harvest and effort.

In the Port Clarence District, catch limits for Pilgrim River sockeye were waived on July 4 when escapement objectives were projected to be achieved. Due to Chinook salmon conservation concerns, the department closed subsistence fishing in the marine and fresh waters of Subdistricts 5 and 6 starting on June 15 and allowed only limited subsistence fishing targeting non-salmon species in freshwaters. Subsistence opportunities were liberalized on June 30, allowing beach seining with the non-retention of Chinook salmon. On July 16 marine waters of Subdistricts 5 and 6 were open to gillnet gear with mesh size restricted to 6 inches or less, and fresh waters were open to subsistence gillnet fishing by emergency order on July 22.

Subsistence harvest data is collected in the months after the end of the salmon season and final estimates are not available for this summary. However, anecdotal evidence from fishermen in the region indicate that most residents were able to meet their salmon needs in the 2026 season. Subsistence fishermen in Port Clarence and the Pilgrim River used beach seines and set gillnets to harvest sockeye salmon. Northern Norton Sound subsistence users reported success catching chum, pink, and coho in marine and freshwater using gillnets and rod and reel. Fishermen in southern Norton Sound were able to put away salmon using beach seine methods to catch chum and pinks early in the season and set gillnets to catch coho salmon after restrictions were lifted.

SEASON SUMMARY BY SUBDISTRICT

Nome - Subdistrict 1

Based on low salmon returns in the previous year, a conservative management approach was taken in Subdistrict 1 for the 2026 season. Lackluster escapement counts for chum salmon early in the season precluded commercial periods, although escapement goals were eventually met in the Snake and Nome rivers west of Cape Nome. East of Cape Nome, chum escapement to the Eldorado River was at historical lows in 2026. Coho salmon escapement monitored by projects in Subdistrict 1 was low and did not indicate a harvestable surplus. Ultimately, there were no commercial fishing periods in Subdistrict 1 in 2026.

Salmon runs were below average in the Nome Subdistrict. Nome River pink salmon did not achieve escapement objectives in 2026, and Eldorado chum salmon escapement was well below the goal range of 4,400–14,200 fish (Table 4). Weir operations on the Nome River were consistent for most of the season, until high water forced the end of the project on September 10. The Snake River weir ran intermittently until the project ceased operations on August 23. Coho salmon passage was below average at assessment projects when high water events caused the weirs to become inoperable. Aerial surveys flown of some Subdistrict 1 rivers on September 22 indicated lackluster escapement abundance of coho salmon.

Golovin - Subdistrict 2

There were 14 commercial fishing periods directed at chum or coho salmon with gillnets restricted to 6 inches or smaller mesh size. There were 14 permit holders that fished this year, which was near the historical average of 15 permits. Catch rates in the chum salmon commercial fishery were generally above the long-term historical average and escapement was near the 75th percentile of historical escapements. The

commercial coho salmon fishery started on July 29 and catch rates for the season were near average. The commercial harvest was 1,054 sockeye, 1,676 chum, and 11,485 coho salmon (Table 2).

Niukluk River tower operations ran fairly consistently in 2026 but was pulled early due to high waters. The project started counting on June 24 and operated until high water events put counts on hold from August 4–13 and ultimately caused the project to end early on August 21. The preliminary counts from the tower are 174 Chinook, 41,326 chum, 1,073,361 pink, 558 sockeye, and 523 coho salmon (Table 4).

Elim - Subdistrict 3

Due to low returns in previous years, the department took a cautious approach to scheduling chum salmon fishery openers in Subdistrict 3. There were 14 commercial fishing periods targeting chum or coho salmon with gillnets restricted to 6 inches or smaller mesh size. The 18 permit holders that fished in 2026 matched the recent 5-year average of 18 permits. Harvest rates for chum salmon during the first fishing period on July 7 were above average and early Kwiniuk River tower chum salmon estimates were projected to meet escapement objectives. This led the department to eventually schedule two 48-hour fishing periods a week until management switched to coho salmon on July 29. Fishing performance during periods directed to coho salmon were generally near average and the escapement goal of 4,400 was achieved in the third week of August. The commercial harvest totaled 906 sockeye, 5,315 chum, 5,509 pink, and 2,276 coho salmon (Table 2).

Of the four established Kwiniuk River escapement goals, three were achieved in 2026. Chinook salmon passage was below the escapement goal of 250 fish for the sixth year in a row. Chum salmon passage met the escapement goal range of 9,100–32,600. The pink salmon escapement goal threshold of 8,400 fish was exceeded. The coho salmon tower-based goal of 4,400 fish, which was newly established at the Board of Fish meeting in November 2025, was achieved. Escapement counts at the Kwiniuk River tower were 63 Chinook, 16,809 chum, 746,600 pink, 300 sockeye, and 6,123 coho salmon (Table 4).

Norton Bay - Subdistrict 4

Subdistrict 4 was managed in conjunction with Subdistricts 2 and 3 in 2026 based on fishing performance. There were 14 commercial fishing periods with gillnets restricted to 6-inch mesh or less. Commercial harvest totaled 140 sockeye, 1,768 chum, 435 pink, and 503 coho salmon, which were all well below average. Effort was sporadic throughout the season and only 5 permits fished, which is below the average participation of 11 permits.

A counting tower on the Ungalik River operated in 2026 but was limited by high water with periods of missed or incomplete escapement and counts should be considered a minimum. Escapement estimates were 36 Chinook salmon, 8,859 chum, 445,879 pink, 276 coho, and 0 sockeye salmon (Table 4).

Shaktoolik and Unalakleet - Subdistricts 5 and 6

Shaktoolik and Unalakleet subdistricts share a common commercial fishing boundary, and management actions typically encompass both subdistricts as salmon intermingle in the marine waters of Subdistricts 5 and 6. In 2026, poor Chinook runs in both subdistricts caused the department to forgo early season salmon openings to allow for additional escapement. Commercial fishing started on July 24, and there were 9 commercial fishing periods targeting coho salmon with gillnets restricted to 6 inches or smaller mesh size. Catch rates for coho salmon were near historical averages. There were 9 permit holders that fished in the

Shaktoolik Subdistrict and in Unalakleet there were 28 permit holders. The Shaktoolik commercial harvest was 421 sockeye, 2,015 chum, 253 pink and 2,383 coho salmon. The Unalakleet commercial harvest was 389 sockeye, 4,147 chum, 1,224 pink and 6,799 coho salmon (Table 2).

There are two counting tower projects in these subdistricts located on the Shaktoolik and North rivers. The Shaktoolik River counting tower started operations on June 26. However, due to high, turbid water the tower operated sporadically during the 2026 season and counted 411 Chinook salmon, 8,067 chum, 349,974 pink, and 1,701 coho salmon. The North River tower began on June 17 and operated more consistently than other projects in southern Norton Sound but still had a long period of unmonitored escapement due to high waters between August 4–12 and operations ended early on August 22. The North River Chinook salmon escapement of 399 fish was well below the lower end of the escapement goal range of 1,200–2,600 fish (Table 4). Other salmon counts at North River tower were 2,787 chum, 469,591 pink, 321 coho, and 9 sockeye salmon.

Port Clarence District

Port Clarence District is home to the furthest north sockeye salmon run in the state. Each year, the seasonal subsistence catch limit is 25 sockeye salmon per household and the department can raise the limit if returns are projected to exceed escapement needs. An early, strong run of sockeye led the department to waive household sockeye limits on July 4. The Pilgrim River weir count of 34,232 sockeye salmon exceeded the escapement threshold of 6,400 fish. To allow for a commercial fishery an escapement of 30,000 sockeye salmon must be projected in the Pilgrim River. Sockeye escapement was adequate for commercial fishing in 2026, but market interest has not existed in over 10 years.

Table 1.– Norton Sound salmon catch and dollar value, 1962–2026.

Year	Total Catch	Number of Permits	Gross Value of Catch to Permit Holders
1962	232,431		$105,800
1963	224,378		$104,000
1964	164,671		$51,000
1965	39,203		$21,483
1966	100,345		$68,000
1967	74,818		$44,038
1968	124,409		$63,700
1969	178,972		$95,297
1970	178,218		$99,019
1971	141,977		$101,000
1972	149,494		$102,225
1973	176,797		$308,740
1974	315,829		$437,127
1975	251,861		$413,255
1976	193,063		$285,283
1977	257,325	164	$546,010
1978	531,948	176	$907,330
1979	350,401	175	$878,792
1980	444,337	159	$572,125
1981	441,734	167	$761,658
1982	511,208	164	$1,069,723
1983	456,420	170	$946,232
1984	342,159	141	$738,064
1985	180,200	155	$818,477
1986	230,400	163	$546,452
1987	136,283	164	$517,894
1988	225,132	152	$760,641
1989	92,811	110	$319,489
1990	131,665	128	$474,064
1991	156,789	126	$413,479
1992	199,933	110	$448,395
1993	263,670	153	$368,723
1994	1,108,184	119	$863,060
1995	181,393	105	$356,164
1996	571,241	86	$340,347
1997	79,141	102	$363,908
1998	641,396	82	$358,982
1999	23,051	60	$76,860
2000	217,873	79	$149,907
2001	30,849	51	$56,921
2002	2,365	12	$2,941
2003	20,653	30	$64,473
2004	48,381	36	$122,506
2005	89,669	40	$296,154

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Table 1.– Page 2 of 2.

Year	Total Catch	Number of Permits	Gross Value of Catch to Permit Holders
2006	140,873	61	$389,707
2007	152,357	71	$572,195
2008	221,101	91	$759,451
2009	138,737	88	$722,167
2010	211,622	115	$1,220,487
2011	177,167	123	$1,269,730
2012	305,657	123	$758,908
2013	181,247	124	$1,183,236
2014	403,715	128	$1,915,749
2015	369,720	128	$1,940,408
2016	366,236	141	$1,237,229
2017	378,561	139	$2,788,316
2018	543,714	149	$4,001,400
2019	381,124	145	$2,078,034
2020	50,679	124	$290,302
2021	303,999	131	$451,815
2022	130,207	108	$465,972
2023	25,096	83	$115,762
2024	21,490	89	$146,326
2025	38,189	76	$449,448
2026	48,700	72	$320,657
Average 2021–2025	103,796	97	$325,865
Average 2016–2025	223,930	119	$1,202,460

Note: Blank cells represent years when data is not available.

Table 2.–Norton Sound commercial salmon harvest summary by subdistrict, 2026.

		Subdistricts						
		1- Nome	2- Golovin	3- Elim	4- Norton Bay	5- Shaktoolik	6- Unalakleet	Total
Number of permit holders		-	14	18	5	9	28	72
Number of commercial periods		-	14	14	14	9	9	60
King	Number	-	0	0	0	0	0	0
	Weight (lbs)	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Sockeye	Number	-	1,054	906	140	421	389	2,910
	Weight (lbs)	-	7,031	5,844	911	2,476	2,317	18,579
Coho	Number	-	1,676	2,278	503	2,383	6,799	13,639
	Weight (lbs)	-	10,016	13,489	3,150	14,010	39,880	80,545
Pink	Number	-	0	5,509	435	253	1,224	7,421
	Weight (lbs)	-	-	15,328	1,227	750	3,429	20,734
Chum	Number	-	11,485	5,315	1,768	2,015	4,147	24,730
	Weight (lbs)	-	75,071	33,902	11,431	12,634	26,341	159,379
Total	Number	0	14,215	14,008	2,846	5,072	12,559	48,700
	Weight (lbs)	0	92,118	68,563	16,719	29,870	71,967	279,237

Table 3.– Norton Sound salmon catch, 1962–2026.

Year	Chinook	Sockeye	Coho	Pink	Chum	Total
1962	7,286	18	9,156	33,187	182,784	232,431
1963	6,613	71	16,765	46,180	154,749	224,378
1964	2,018	126	98	13,567	148,862	164,671
1965	128	30	2,030	220	36,795	39,203
1966	1,553	14	5,755	12,778	80,245	100,345
1967	1,804	0	2,379	28,879	41,756	74,818
1968	1,045	0	6,885	71,179	45,300	124,409
1969	2,392	0	6,836	86,949	82,795	178,972
1970	1,853	0	4,423	64,908	107,034	178,218
1971	2,593	0	3,127	4,895	131,362	141,977
1972	2,938	0	454	45,182	100,920	149,494
1973	1,918	0	9,282	46,499	119,098	176,797
1974	2,951	0	2,092	148,519	162,267	315,829
1975	2,393	2	4,593	32,388	212,485	251,861
1976	2,243	11	6,934	87,919	95,956	193,063
1977	4,500	5	3,690	48,675	200,455	257,325
1978	9,819	12	7,335	325,503	189,279	531,948
1979	10,706	57	31,438	167,411	140,789	350,401
1980	6,311	40	29,842	227,352	180,792	444,337
1981	7,929	56	31,562	232,479	169,708	441,734
1982	5,892	10	91,690	230,281	183,335	511,208
1983	10,308	27	49,735	76,913	319,437	456,420
1984	8,455	6	67,875	119,381	146,442	342,159
1985	19,491	166	21,968	3,647	134,928	180,200
1986	6,395	233	35,600	41,260	146,912	230,400
1987	7,080	207	24,279	2,260	102,457	136,283
1988	4,096	1,252	37,214	74,604	107,966	225,132
1989	5,707	265	44,091	123	42,625	92,811
1990	8,895	434	56,712	501	65,123	131,665
1991	6,068	203	63,647	0	86,871	156,789
1992	4,541	296	105,418	6,284	83,394	199,933
1993	8,972	279	43,283	157,574	53,562	263,670
1994	5,285	80	102,140	982,389	18,290	1,108,184
1995	8,860	128	47,863	81,664	42,898	181,393
1996	4,984	1	68,206	487,441	10,609	571,241
1997	12,573	161	32,284	20	34,103	79,141
1998	7,429	7	29,623	588,013	16,324	641,396
1999	2,508	0	12,662	0	7,881	23,051
2000	752	14	44,409	166,548	6,150	217,873
2001	213	44	19,492	0	11,100	30,849
2002	5	1	1,759	0	600	2,365
2003	12	21	17,060	0	3,560	20,653
2004	22	47	42,016	0	6,296	48,381
2005	151	12	85,523	0	3,983	89,669

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Year	Chinook	Sockeye	Coho	Pink	Chum	Total
2006	20	3	130,808	0	10,042	140,873
2007	19	2	126,136	3,769	22,431	152,357
2008	83	60	120,309	75,525	25,124	221,101
2009	84	126	87,041	17,364	34,122	138,737
2010	140	103	62,079	31,557	117,743	211,622
2011	185	369	58,917	7,141	110,555	177,167
2012	197	134	37,056	205,498	62,772	305,657
2013	151	247	53,802	8,338	118,709	181,247
2014	289	519	112,756	182,406	107,745	403,715
2015	1,288	4,119	153,928	62,888	147,497	369,720
2016	321	2,888	102,890	208,961	51,176	366,236
2017	538	2,975	191,254	20,321	163,473	378,561
2018	906	3,623	260,707	40,449	238,029	543,714
2019	1,371	6,969	139,820	75,929	157,035	381,124
2020	906	1,808	14,650	6,950	26,365	50,679
2021	15	473	7,189	289,912	6,410	303,999
2022	0	1,233	13,464	84,261	31,249	130,207
2023	0	364	5,426	3,613	15,693	25,096
2024	0	294	13,878	3,229	4,232	21,633
2025	0	651	31,523	46	5,969	38,189
2026	0	2,910	13,639	7,421	24,730	48,700
Average 2021–2025	3	603	14,296	76,212	12,711	103,825
Average 2016–2025	406	2,128	78,080	73,367	69,963	223,944

Table 4.–Salmon counts and associated salmon escapement goal ranges, Norton Sound and Port Clarence Districts, 2026.

	Chinook salmon			Chum salmon		
Stream	Weir/ tower count	Aerial survey count	Escapement goal	Weir/ tower count	Aerial survey count	Escapement goal
Salmon L.						
Grand Central R.						
Pilgrim R.	21			13,538		
Glacial L.						
Sinuk R.					1,040	
Cripple R.						
Penny R.						
Anvil Creek						
Snake R.	1			2,104		2,000-4,200
Nome R.	1			1,685		1,600-5,300
Flambeau R.		1			710	
Eldorado R.	1	0		879	6	4,400-14,200
Bonanza R.		0			590	
Solomon R.					540	
Fish R.		5			1,500	
Boston Cr.						
Niukluk R.	174			41,326		
Ophir Cr.						
Casadepaga R.						
Kwiniuk R.	63		250	16,809		9,100-32,600
Tubutulik R.						
Ungalik R.	36			8,358		
Inglutalik R						
Shaktoolik R.	411	269		8,067	7,800	
Unalakleet R.						
Old Woman R.		59			720	
North R.	399	157	1,200-2,600	2,787	1,600	

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Table 4.– Page 2 of 2.

	Coho salmon			Sockeye salmon			Pink salmon		
Stream	Weir/ tower count	Aerial survey count	Escapement goal	Weir/ tower count	Aerial survey count	Escapement goal	Weir/ tower count	Aerial survey count	Escapement goal
Salmon L.					2,940				
Grand Central R.					4,020				
Pilgrim R.	168			34,232		6,400	3,044		
Glacial L.					9,810	800-1,600			
Sinuk R.					100			19,100	
Cripple R.									
Penny R.									
Anvil Creek									
Snake R.	89	618		16			1,716		
Nome R.	113	75		53			6,199		13,000
Flambeau R.		78			0			1,100	
Eldorado R.	0	135		0	0		1,797	1,100	
Bonanza R.		51			10			24,100	
Solomon R.	1				30			31,180	
Fish R.					3			1,303,000	
Boston Cr.									
Niukluk R.	523		**Combined**	558			1,073,376		
Ophir Cr.			**750-1,600**						
Casadepaga R.									
Kwiniuk R.	6,123		4,400	300			770,900		8,400
Tubutulik R.									
Ungalik R.	0			0			426,727		
Inglutalik R									
Shaktoolik R.	1,701			159			349,974		
Unalakleet R.									
Old Woman R.									
North R.	321		550-1,100	9			469,591		25,000

Note: Data not available for all streams. Sustainable escapement goal (SEG) and optimal escapement goal (OEG) are listed.
All aerial surveys are rated fair to good, unless otherwise noted.

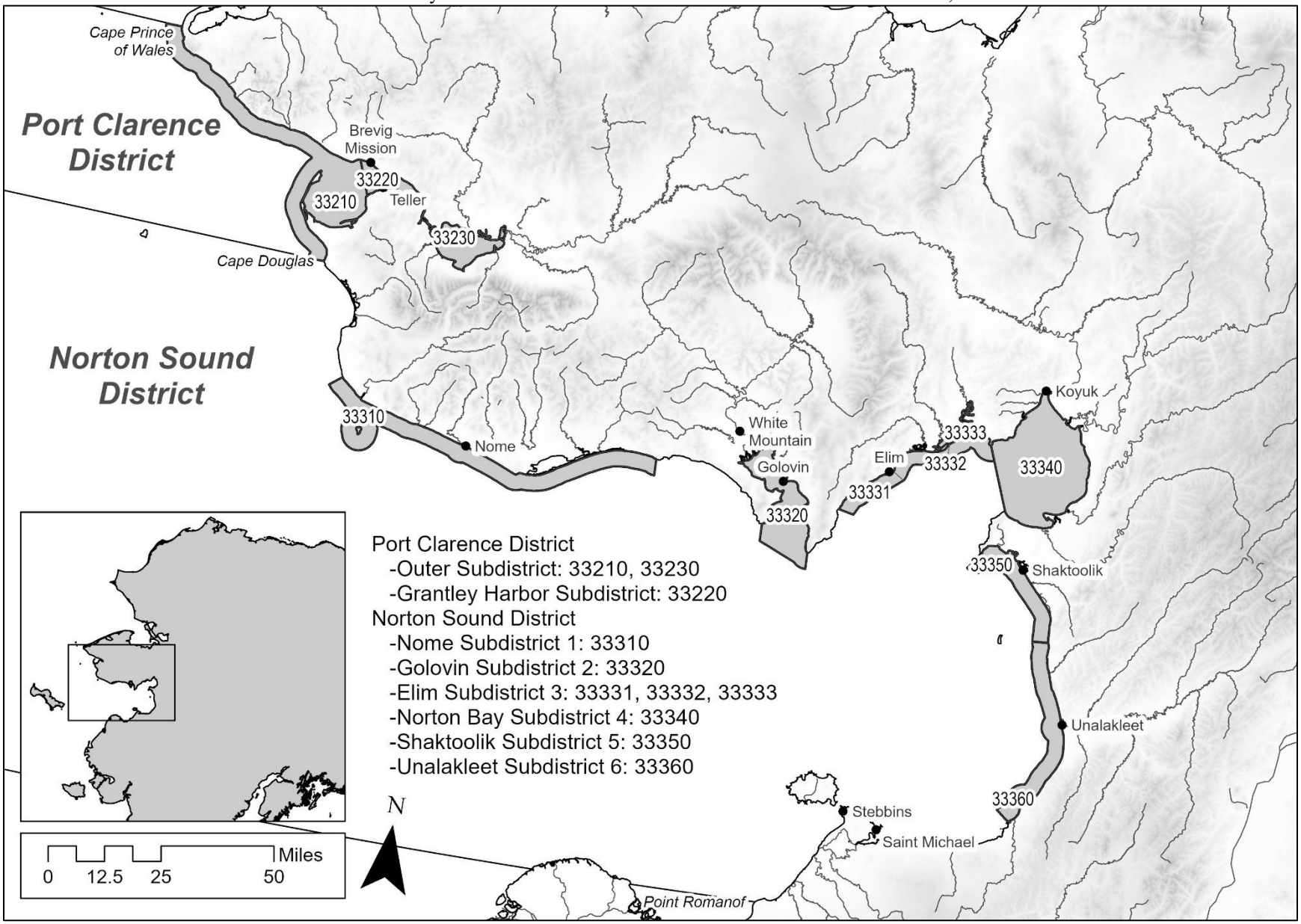


Figure 1.– Norton Sound and Port Clarence commercial salmon fishing districts, subdistricts, and stat areas.